

The Great Sūtra Called The Five-and-Three

Pañcatriyānāma Mahāsūtra · Toh 294 · Derge Kangyur

མད་ཚེ་པ་ལྷ་གསུམ་པ་ནས་བ་བྱ།

The Great Sūtra Called The Five-and-Three, known in Sanskrit as the Pañcatriyānāma Mahāsūtra and in Tibetan as Mdo chen po lnga gsum pa zhes bya ba, is a Buddhist sūtra in which the Buddha addresses a gathering of monks at Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove. The text concerns the various metaphysical positions held by ascetics and brahmins regarding perception, non-perception, annihilation, and liberation, systematically examining the views through which such thinkers make declarations about existence and the self. Its title appears to reflect a structural arrangement of five and three categories that organize the discourse. It is Toh 294 in the Kangyur, belonging to the general class of sūtra literature.

In the language of India: Pañcatriyānāma Mahāsūtram. In the Tibetan language: The Great Sūtra Called The Five-and-Three.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, in the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada.

Then the Blessed One addressed the monks: "Monks, all those ascetics (śramaṇas) and brahmins who make declarations about the many bases of their views, all of them make their declarations in terms of five positions. What are the five? Some declare: 'From this point forward, I shall become one who possesses perception.' Others declare: 'I shall be without perception,' or 'I shall be neither with perception nor without perception.' And there is annihilation. And yet others make the declaration: 'In this very life I shall pass into nirvāṇa.'

"Among those ascetics and brahmins endowed with knowledge who speak of possessing perception, some hold that a self exists, and they declare: 'From this point forward, I shall become one who possesses perception.' Others declare: 'There will be annihilation.' And yet others make the declaration: 'In this very life I shall pass into nirvāṇa.' When these five are present they become three, and when the three are present they become five. This is a brief presentation of the Dharma category called The Five-and-Three.

"Monks, now among those ascetics and brahmins who speak of possessing perception, those who make the declaration: 'From this point forward, I shall become one who possesses a self with perception' — those ascetics and

brahmins endowed with knowledge who speak in this way, some hold that a self exists, and they declare: 'From this point forward, I shall become one who possesses perception and has form,' or 'one who is formless,' or 'one who has a single unified perception,' or 'one who has varied perceptions,' or 'one who has a limited perception,' or 'one who has come to have a vast perception,' or 'one who has boundless perception.' And yet others, turning away from all of that, make the declaration: 'That is the sense base of infinite consciousness.'

"The Tathāgata knows correctly and precisely those ascetics and brahmins who speak of possessing perception, those who make the declaration: 'From this point forward, I shall become one who possesses perception' — those ascetics and brahmins endowed with knowledge who speak in this way, some holding that a self exists — who declare: 'From this point forward, I shall become one who possesses perception and has form,' or 'formless,' or 'with a single unified perception,' or 'with varied perceptions,' or 'with a limited perception,' or 'with a vast perception,' or 'with boundless perception' — and those who, turning away from all of that, make the declaration: 'That is the sense base of infinite consciousness.'

"Monks, those with varying perceptions and varying designations declare: 'Having perfectly passed beyond the sense base of infinite consciousness in every respect, there is nothing whatsoever,' and, having established the sense base of nothingness, they abide there — non-dual, unmoving. This, they say, is supreme; this is unsurpassable.

"Monks, that is gross, compounded, intended, and dependently originated. And since formations exist, there is also the cessation of formations. Knowing this to be the case, the Tathāgata turns back from that, beholds its pacification, and dwells beholding its definitive transcendence."

"Monks, in this regard there are ascetics and brahmins who advocate the absence of perception and who make declarations — some declaring: 'Henceforth I shall become one without perception.' These contradict and censure what is asserted by those ascetics and brahmins who advocate the presence of perception and who make declarations — some declaring: 'Henceforth I shall become one with perception.' They censure it, and they think to themselves: 'Perception is a disease. Perception is a boil. Perception is a thorn. This — the absence of perception — is peaceful. This is sublime.' And the Tathāgata fully knows, exactly as it is, those ascetics and brahmins who advocate the absence of perception and who make such declarations — some

declaring: 'Henceforth I shall become one without perception' — and who contradict and censure what is asserted by those ascetics and brahmins who advocate the presence of perception and who make declarations — some declaring: 'Henceforth I shall become one with perception.' They censure it, and they think: 'Perception is a disease. Perception is a boil. Perception is a thorn. The absence of perception — this is peaceful. This is sublime.'

"Monks, I do not designate consciousness as coming or going, as persisting, as passing away or being reborn, as growing, increasing, and expanding — as something other than form, other than feeling, other than perception, other than formations. Monks, if anyone says: 'I designate consciousness as coming or going, as persisting, as passing away or being reborn, as growing, increasing, and expanding — as something other than form, other than feeling, other than perception, other than formations' — that is nothing more than words, and since it falls outside the domain of valid experience, if questioned on it, that person will not truly know and will become confused in answering.

"Monks, that too is gross, compounded, intended, and dependently originated. And since formations exist, there is also the cessation of formations. Knowing this to be the case, the Tathāgata turns back from that, beholds its pacification, and dwells beholding its definitive transcendence.

"Monks, in this regard there are ascetics and brahmins who advocate neither the presence nor the absence of perception, and who make declarations — some declaring: 'Henceforth I shall become one who has neither perception nor the absence of perception.' These contradict and censure what is asserted by those ascetics and brahmins who advocate the presence of perception and who make declarations — some declaring: 'Henceforth I shall become one with perception.' They censure it. And they also contradict and censure what is asserted by those ascetics and brahmins who advocate the absence of perception and who make declarations — some declaring: 'Henceforth I shall become one without perception.' They censure it, and they think: 'Perception is a disease. Perception is a boil. Perception is a thorn. And the total absence of perception is confusion. This — the sense base of neither perception nor non-perception — is peaceful. This is sublime.' And the Tathāgata fully knows those ascetics and brahmins who advocate neither the presence nor the absence of perception and who make such declarations — some declaring: 'Henceforth I shall become one who has neither perception nor the absence of perception —'"

— some declaring: 'Henceforth I shall become one who has neither perception nor the absence of perception.' Those ascetics and brahmins who advocate the presence of perception, and who make declarations — some declaring: 'Henceforth I shall become one who has perception' — they contend against and censure what those others have said. And those ascetics and brahmins who advocate the absence of perception, and who make declarations — some declaring: 'Henceforth I shall become one without perception' — they too contend against and censure what those others have said. And those latter think: 'Perception is a disease. Perception is a boil. Perception is a thorn. And the total absence of perception is confusion. This sense base of neither perception nor non-perception — this is peaceful. This is sublime.' The Tathāgata fully knows even those who think thus.

Monks, I do not say that one will attain that remaining sense base of formations merely through what one has seen, heard, distinguished, known, through moral discipline, through ascetic observance, through livelihood, through the holy life, through austerity, or through devoted service. Monks, I do say that one will attain that sense base through entering into the meditative absorption of the summit of existence.

Monks, that very appearance of striving for it is itself an affliction of that sense base. The Tathāgata fully knows, exactly as they are, those who are distressed and those who strive. Monks, that too is coarse, conditioned, intended, and arisen through dependent origination. And since, where formations exist, there also exists the cessation of formations, the Tathāgata, having understood that this exists, turns away from it and sees, abides seeing, its peace and its complete emergence.

Monks, as for those ascetics and brahmins who advocate annihilation and who make declarations — some declaring: 'Henceforth I shall become annihilated' — they contend against and censure what those ascetics and brahmins who advocate the presence of perception have said, namely those who declare: 'Henceforth I shall become one who has perception.' They also contend against and censure what those ascetics and brahmins who advocate the absence of perception have said, namely those who declare: 'Henceforth I shall become one without perception.' And they contend against and censure what those ascetics and brahmins who advocate neither the presence nor the absence of perception have said, namely those who declare: 'Henceforth I shall become one who has neither perception nor the absence of perception.' And those latter think: 'All these ascetics and brahmins who are

knowledgeable, who speak with good aspirations looking to the future, all of them declare as a declaration only a good aspiration, saying: "In the future let us become such and such; in the future let us become such and such." It is like a merchant who, when engaging in trade with his merchandise, thinks: "Having taken such and such from this merchandise of mine, I shall go elsewhere; and when I arrive there, such and such profits will come to be for me." In just the same way, those ascetics and brahmins who are knowledgeable —'

all those knowledgeable ascetics and brahmins who speak with good aspirations looking to the future — all of them declare as a declaration only a good aspiration, saying: "In the future let us become such and such; in the future let us become such and such." Those among them think: "That is just like a merchant." And they think further: "For as long as this gross, form-possessing body of mine, arisen from the four great elements, is alive and dwelling, continuing to live — for that long it is accompanied by illness, accompanied by disease, accompanied by pain, accompanied by fever, accompanied by utter distress. But from the moment of my death onward, since I shall be cut off and cease to arise again, to that extent I shall be truly and perfectly cut off."

For as long as one approaches and dwells in the gods of the desire realm, the gods of the form realm, the formless base of infinite space (ākāśānantyāyatana), the formless base of infinite consciousness (vijñānānantyāyatana), the formless base of nothingness (ākimcanyāyatana), the formless base of neither-perception-nor-non-perception (naivasamjñānāsamjñāyatana), and is alive and dwelling, continuing to live — for that long it is accompanied by illness, accompanied by disease, accompanied by pain, accompanied by fever, accompanied by utter distress. But from the moment of my death onward, since I shall be cut off and cease to arise again, to that extent I shall be truly and perfectly cut off.

In this way, the Tathāgata holds that those ascetics and brahmins who are annihilationists — those among them who declare "From this point onward I shall become annihilated" — contradict and censure what those ascetics and brahmins who speak of a conscious self (those who declare "From this point onward I shall come to have perception") have declared. They also contradict and censure what those ascetics and brahmins who speak of an unconscious self (those who declare "From this point onward I shall come to be without perception") have declared. And they also contradict and censure what those

ascetics and brahmins who speak of a self that is neither conscious nor unconscious (those who declare "From this point onward I shall come to be neither having perception nor lacking perception") have declared.

And those latter think: "All these ascetics and brahmins who are knowledgeable, who speak with good aspirations looking to the future — all of them declare as a declaration only a good aspiration, saying: 'In the future let us become such and such; in the future let us become such and such.' It is like a merchant who, when engaging in trade with his merchandise, thinks: 'Having taken such and such from this merchandise of mine, I shall go elsewhere; and when I arrive there, such and such profits will come to be for me.' In just the same way, all those ascetics and brahmins who are knowledgeable, who speak with good aspirations looking to the future, declare as a declaration only a good aspiration, saying: 'In the future let us become such and such; in the future let us become such and such.'" Those among them think: "That is just like a merchant." And they think further:

"For as long as this self of mine is corporeal, coarse, arisen from the four great elements, alive and persisting, dwelling and continuing to live — for that long it is accompanied by illness, accompanied by tumors, accompanied by sharp pains, accompanied by fevers, accompanied by utter torment. But from the moment of my death onward, this self of mine shall be cut off, shall perish, and shall not come to be again — to that extent this self of mine will be thoroughly and completely cut off." For as long as one draws near to the gods of the desire realm, the gods of the form realm, the formless sphere of infinite space, the formless sphere of infinite consciousness, the formless sphere of nothingness, the formless sphere of neither-perception-nor-non-perception, and remains alive, persisting, dwelling and continuing to live — for that long it is accompanied by illness, accompanied by tumors, accompanied by sharp pains, accompanied by fevers, accompanied by utter torment. But from the moment of death onward, this self of mine shall be cut off, shall perish, and shall not come to be again — to that extent this self of mine will be thoroughly and completely cut off. Those who think thus, the Tathāgata knows exactly as they truly are.

Monks, as for those ascetics and brahmins who are possessed of knowledge, who speak of annihilation, and who assert annihilation, perishing, and non-existence with respect to sentient beings that do exist — in them there remains a residue of the mass of ignorance. And to the extent that there remains a residue of the mass of ignorance, to that extent there is fear of the

perishing of the transient collection, and being afraid and terrified of the transient collection, they go about disparaging that very transient collection alone. Yet at the very time they are disparaging the transient collection alone, those very people are attached to nothing other than the transient collection.

Monks, that too is coarse, conditioned, intended, and dependently originated. And since, given that formations exist, there also exists the cessation of formations, the Tathāgata, having understood this, turns away from it, seeing peace in it, seeing definitive release, and abides accordingly.

Monks, with respect to those who speculate about the further end — those who articulate and proclaim the various speculative views accompanied by theories about the further end — there are just so many of them. Those are called the various speculative views accompanied by theories about the further end.

Monks, as for those who speculate about the former end — how many are those who articulate and proclaim the various speculative views accompanied by theories about the former end? Monks, those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the former end — among them, some hold and declare views such as these: that the self and the world are permanent; that the self and the world are impermanent; that they are both permanent and impermanent; that they are neither permanent nor impermanent; that the self and suffering are permanent; that the self and suffering are impermanent; that they are both permanent and impermanent; that they are neither permanent nor impermanent; that the self and the world are self-made; that the self and the world are made by another; that they are both self-made and made by another; that they arose from no cause, being neither self-made nor made by another; that the self and suffering are self-made; that the self and suffering are made by another; that they are both self-made and made by another; that they arose from no cause, being neither self-made nor made by another. Among those who hold such views and speak in such terms, the Tathāgata knows exactly as they truly are — those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the former end, those among them who hold and proclaim the view that the self and the world are permanent — those too the Tathāgata knows exactly as they truly are. Those ascetics and brahmins are without faith and

without desire, without learning through transmission, without thorough examination of appearances, and without the patient acceptance born of personal insight — the Tathāgata knows this too exactly as it truly is, and

understands that any thinking which regards such knowledge as actually existing has no ground to stand on. When those various ascetics and brahmins who do possess knowledge come to understand these things, and yet — though lacking that knowledge themselves — still proclaim themselves knowers and declare that they alone stand in perfect purity, this can only appear as sheer ignorance on their part. For monks, even that is coarse, conditioned, thought-out, and dependently originated. And since, where formations exist, the cessation of formations also exists, the Tathāgata, having fully comprehended this, turns back from it, sees its stilling, sees the going-forth from it, and abides in that vision.

The Tathāgata knows exactly as they truly are all those ascetics and brahmins who speculate about the former end and who hold and proclaim the view that the self and the world are permanent; that the self and the world are impermanent; that they are both permanent and impermanent; that they are neither permanent nor impermanent; that the self and suffering are permanent; that the self and suffering are impermanent; that they are both permanent and impermanent; that they are neither permanent nor impermanent; that the self and the world are self-made; that the self and the world are made by another; that they are both self-made and made by another; that they arose from no cause, being neither self-made nor made by another; that the self and suffering are self-made; that the self and suffering are made by another; that they are both self-made and made by another; that they arose from no cause, being neither self-made nor made by another — all those who hold such views and speak in such terms and make such declarations, the Tathāgata knows exactly as they truly are. He knows too that those ascetics and brahmins are without faith, without desire, without learning through transmission, without thorough examination of appearances, and without the patient acceptance born of personal insight, and that any thinking which regards such knowledge as actually existing has no ground to stand on. When those various ascetics and brahmins who do possess knowledge come to understand these things, and yet — though lacking that knowledge themselves — still proclaim themselves knowers and declare that they alone stand in perfect purity, this can only appear as sheer ignorance on their part. For monks, even that is coarse, conditioned, thought-out, and dependently originated. And since, where formations exist, the cessation of formations also exists, the Tathāgata, having fully comprehended this, turns back from it, sees its stilling, sees the going-forth from it, and abides in that vision.

Monks, those who speculate about the former end and who hold and proclaim the various forms of view pertaining to the former end — all such forms are to be reckoned as views pertaining to the former end, and they number exactly so many. Monks, now as for those who proclaim nirvāṇa in this very life and declare that one passes into nirvāṇa in this very life — how many such forms are there? Monks, in this case there are certain ascetics or brahmins who have fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the former end and have fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end, and having fully abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life, have directly realized with the body the joy of seclusion, have attained it, and abide in it. Such a one thinks: "Thus have I fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the former end, fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end, and having fully abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life —

having directly realized with the body the joy of seclusion, having attained it and abiding in it — this joy of seclusion is peaceful, this is excellent." The Tathāgata fully knows, exactly as it is and in accordance with reality, the thought of whatever ascetic or brahmin who has fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the former end, fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end, and having fully abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life, directly realizes with the body the joy of seclusion, attains it, and abides in it — and who then thinks: "Thus have I fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the former end, fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end, and having fully abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life, having directly realized with the body the joy of seclusion, having attained it and abiding in it — this joy of seclusion is peaceful, this is excellent."

Monks, that joy of seclusion is impermanent and subject to cessation. From the cessation of the bliss of seclusion there arises mental discomfort, and from the cessation of mental discomfort there arises the joy of seclusion. Monks, it is just like this: when shadow recedes, sunlight pervades; and when sunlight recedes, shadow pervades. In the same way, from the cessation of the joy of seclusion there arises mental discomfort, and from the cessation of mental discomfort there arises the joy of seclusion.

Monks, that too is coarse, compounded, contrived, and dependently originated. Now, since there are formations, there is also the cessation of formations. The Tathāgata, having understood that, turns away from it, sees

its pacification, sees the going forth from it, and so abides.

Monks, furthermore, there is here some ascetic or brahmin who has fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the former end, fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end, and having fully abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life, has completely transcended the joy of seclusion and directly realizes with the body the bliss that is without material support, has attained it and abides in it. Such a one thinks: "Thus have I fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the former end, fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end, and having fully abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life, having completely transcended the joy of seclusion, having directly realized with the body the bliss that is without material support, having attained it and abiding in it — this bliss without material support is peaceful, this is excellent."

The Tathāgata fully knows whatever ascetic or brahmin who has fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the former end, fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end, having fully abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life, having completely transcended the joy of seclusion, having directly realized with the body the bliss that is without material support, having attained it and abiding in it, thinks: "Thus have I fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the former end, fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end —

having fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end, having fully abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life, having completely transcended the joy of seclusion, having directly realized with the body the bliss that is without material support, having attained it and abiding in it, thinks: 'This bliss without material support is peaceful. This is sublime' — that too the Tathāgata knows completely and correctly, just as it is.

Monks, that bliss without material support is also impermanent and subject to cessation. From the cessation of the bliss without material support, suffering arises; and from the cessation of suffering, the bliss without material support arises. Monks, it is just like this: springwater at times dries up and at times flows again. In the same way, from the cessation of the bliss without material support, suffering arises; and from the cessation of suffering, the bliss without material support arises.

Monks, that too is coarse, conditioned, intended, and dependently originated. And since formations exist, there is also the cessation of formations. The Tathāgata, having understood that this exists, turns away from it and abides seeing its peacefulness, seeing its renunciation.

Monks, furthermore, there is here some ascetic or brahmin who has fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the former end, has fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end, having fully abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life, having completely transcended the joy of seclusion, having also completely transcended the bliss without material support, having directly realized with the body the feeling that is neither suffering nor pleasure, having attained it and abides therein. And that person thinks: 'Thus have I fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the former end, fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end, having fully abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life, having completely transcended the joy of seclusion, having also completely transcended the bliss without material support, having directly realized with the body the feeling that is neither painful nor pleasant, having attained it and abiding in it — this feeling that is neither suffering nor pleasure is peaceful. This is sublime.'

The Tathāgata knows whatever ascetic or brahmin who has fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the former end, has fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end, having fully abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life, having completely transcended the joy of seclusion, having also completely transcended the bliss without material support, having directly realized with the body the feeling that is neither painful nor pleasant, having attained it and abides therein, thinks: 'Thus have I fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the former end, fully abandoned the various forms of view pertaining to the future end, having fully abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life, having completely transcended the joy of seclusion, having also completely transcended the bliss without material support, having directly realized with the body the feeling that is neither suffering nor pleasure, having attained it and abiding in it — this feeling that is neither suffering nor pleasure is peaceful. This is sublime.' That too the Tathāgata knows completely and correctly, just as it is.

Monks, the feeling that is neither painful nor pleasant is also impermanent and subject to cessation. From the cessation of the feeling that is neither suffering

nor

pleasure, both pleasure and pain arise; and from the cessation of pleasure and pain, the feeling that is neither suffering nor pleasure arises. Monks, consider this example: when a firebrand is hurled into the sky, it falls back either on its handle or on its tip. In just the same way, monks, from the cessation of the feeling that is neither suffering nor pleasure, pleasure and pain arise; and from the cessation of pleasure and pain, the feeling that is neither suffering nor pleasure arises.

Monks, that too is coarse, conditioned, intentionally produced, and arisen through dependent origination. Since formations exist, the cessation of formations also exists. Knowing that this is so, the Tathāgata turns away from it, sees it as peaceful, and abides seeing it as leading to liberation.

Monks, furthermore, there is in this world some ascetic or brahmin who has completely abandoned all views associated with the extreme of the past, and has also completely abandoned all views associated with the extreme of the future, and who, having in this very life completely abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence, having completely transcended the joy of seclusion, having also completely transcended the bliss without material support, and having also completely transcended the feeling that is neither suffering nor pleasure, says: 'I am at peace. I have attained nirvāṇa. I am without craving. I am without clinging. What was formerly a self in me is now no longer in me.' The Tathāgata knows completely and correctly, just as it is, any such ascetic or brahmin who has abandoned all views associated with the extreme of the past, abandoned all views associated with the extreme of the future, and in this very life abandoned engagement in sensual indulgence, having completely transcended the joy of seclusion, having also completely transcended the bliss without material support, and having also completely transcended the feeling that is neither suffering nor pleasure, and who says: 'I am at peace. I have attained nirvāṇa. I am without craving. I am without clinging. What was formerly a self in me is now no longer in me.' Yet this should be understood as follows: that venerable one has not truly passed beyond the path that leads in accordance with clinging.

For it should be understood that he still clings: he clings to the views associated with the extreme of the past, and to the views associated with the extreme of the future, and to engagement in sensual indulgence in this very life, and to the joy of seclusion, and to the bliss without material support, and

to the feeling that is neither suffering nor pleasure. And when he says: 'I am at peace. I have attained nirvāṇa. I am without craving. I am without clinging. What was formerly a self in me is now no longer in me' — that very statement appears to be nothing other than clinging on his part.

Monks, that too is coarse, conditioned, intentionally produced, and arisen through dependent origination. Since formations exist, the cessation of formations also exists. Knowing that this is so, the Tathāgata turns away from it, sees it as peaceful, and abides seeing it as leading to liberation.

Monks, there are just so many ways in which those who proclaim nirvāṇa in this very life declare and set forth their proclamation of nirvāṇa in this very life.

Monks, there is yet another supreme attainment that I, by my own direct knowledge, have fully and perfectly awakened to and proclaimed — I, the unsurpassed guide of persons to be trained. Monks, what is that other supreme attainment that I, the unsurpassed guide of persons to be trained, have fully and perfectly awakened to by my own direct knowledge and proclaimed? Monks, it is this: the liberation that is undefiled and unconditioned, through the exhaustion of all defilements. Monks, that is the supreme attainment that I, the unsurpassed guide of persons to be trained, have directly known, fully and perfectly awakened to, and proclaimed.

Having thus declared this, the Blessed One fell silent. Those monks rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had taught.

The summary verse reads:

Diverse perceptions and form,
views of annihilation and permanence,
shade, water, and a walking staff,
and the final person to be tamed.

The Great Sūtra, the Fifty-Third, is complete.

Translated by the Indian masters Jinamitra and Prajñāvarman, together with the great editor-translator the monk Ye shes sde and others, who rendered, reviewed, and established the final text.

Translator's Notes

- The title Pañcatriyanāma Mahāsūtram is a hybrid Sanskrit formation meaning "The Great Sūtra Called the Five-and-Three," corresponding precisely to the Tibetan mdo chen po lnga

gsum pa. The sūtra belongs to the category of discourses analyzing speculative views about the self and its posthumous condition, closely parallel to passages in the Pāli Dīgha and Aṅguttara Nikāyas dealing with sassatavāda and ucchedavāda. The phrase rendered "from this point forward I shall become one who possesses perception" (de pha chad bdag 'du shes can du 'gyur ro) reflects the Tibetan rendering of a standard Indic formulation about the post-mortem continuity or non-continuity of the self — a concern of the speculative teachers being described. The final paragraph's characterization of even the attainment of the base of nothingness as "gross, compounded, intended, and dependently originated" is a doctrinal marker that the Tathāgata has insight surpassing all such attainments.

- The phrase rendered "falls outside the domain of valid experience" translates "yul ma yin pa'i phyir," literally "because it is not a [valid] object or domain." The doctrinal point is that positing consciousness as a self-subsisting entity apart from the other aggregates is not a position that can be coherently investigated or answered, since it does not correspond to any actual object of cognition. This is a key early Buddhist argument against the notion of a standalone, aggregate-transcending self-consciousness.

The word "ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་" rendered here as "boil" follows the standard Pāli parallel (gaṇḍa) found in the Mahādukkhakkhandha-sutta and related texts, where the three terms "disease, boil, thorn" are a stock formula for what is to be rejected. The Tibetan "ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་" (literally "fruit" or "result") is unusual here; the Pāli has "gaṇḍa" (boil, tumor), and the Tibetan is almost certainly a rendering of that term. This is a genuine philological point worth noting.

- The phrase rendered "sense base of formations" translates "'du byed kyi skye mched," which is unusual — most parallel passages refer to the sense base of neither perception nor non-perception. The Tibetan here appears to use "formations" where the expected term would be "neither perception nor non-perception," and this may reflect a variant reading or scribal issue in the Tibetan; the translation follows the Tibetan as it stands.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the close, consistent with a continuation in the following segment.

- The passage is a section of the Brahmajāla-sūtra or a related text cataloguing the sixty-two speculative views, here focused on annihilationist doctrines (ucchedavāda). The Tibetan term rendered "accompanied by illness, disease, pain, fever, and utter distress" follows the standard Pāli/Sanskrit fivefold formula for physical suffering in the three realms. The formless attainments are listed in their canonical ascending order. The final sentence is deliberately left open — mirroring the structure of the preceding translated passage — as the Tibetan itself breaks off with "And they think further," anticipating the continuation in the next passage.

- The phrase rendered "transient collection" throughout translates the Tibetan term for the five aggregates viewed as a perishable cluster, corresponding to the Sanskrit satkāya. The term here carries its technical sense as the object of the view of self, and "fear of the transient collection perishing" reflects the irony the text is drawing: those who preach annihilation are, precisely because they still have a residue of ignorance, still in the grip of attachment to the very thing they claim to deny. The final sentence is grammatically incomplete in the source passage, ending mid-clause, which corresponds to the passage break supplied.

- The phrase rendered "patient acceptance born of personal insight" translates a compound meaning acceptance or tolerance arising from what one has seen directly, that is, a kind of conviction or acquiescence grounded in one's own direct seeing rather than received teaching. This is a technical epistemological term in this sūtra context distinguishing valid personal realization from secondhand understanding. The repetition of the long catalog of views is exact in the Tibetan and is preserved in full as it stands in the source.

- The term rendered "bliss without material support" translates རྣམ་ཐོས་ཀྱི་སྤྱི་བྱུང་ལྔ་ལྔ་ལྔ་, literally "bliss without material substance." The Pali parallel uses nirāmisā-sukha, meaning

"spiritual" or "unworldly" happiness — happiness not dependent on material or sensory supports. This is a step higher in the contemplative progression than the joy of seclusion and likely refers to the joy of the formless or supramundane states. The rendering "without material support" preserves the literal force while conveying the doctrinal sense.

- The passage is structured as a careful doctrinal exposition of progressively subtler states, moving from the bliss without material support to the neutral feeling beyond both pleasure and pain, each shown to be conditioned and therefore subject to arising and cessation. The simile of springwater that at times dries up and at times flows again renders the Tibetan ལྷན་ལྷན་ལྷན་ལྷན་, literally "luminous water" or "clear spring water," as a natural image of intermittent flow. The translation ends mid-sentence following the Tibetan as given, which itself breaks off mid-passage.

- The firebrand simile for the cycling of the three feelings is a traditional illustration; the Tibetan clearly reads "handle" and "tip" for the two ways the thrown brand can land, which corresponds exactly to the Sanskrit counterpart texts in the Pāli parallels.

The phrase rendered "path that leads in accordance with clinging" translates a construction meaning literally "the path of going that is in conformity with clinging" — the doctrinal point being that despite the practitioner's claim to liberation, his very assertion betrays residual appropriation and thus he has not truly escaped the conditioned process.

- The closing summary verse is a mnemonic listing the key topics of the sūtra set. The final line, "the final person to be tamed," refers to the highest attainment described at the sūtra's close, marking it as the culminating teaching among the topics enumerated. The phrase "unconditioned liberation" renders the Tibetan literally as liberation that is both undefiled and not compounded, corresponding to the Sanskrit anāsrava-asamskṛta-vimukti, the ultimate nirvāṇa distinguished from all conditioned states discussed earlier in the sūtra.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.